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Zande blood-brotherhood

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“The pattern of behaviour between blood-brothers is one of intimacy and equality. One way in which intimacy and equality are expressed between the partners is by each publicly insulting the other.... Thus one will shout to the other:

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‘Ai friend! may they cut into your witchcraft! You are witches, you of the Akalinga clan! ’ To which the blood-brother replies:

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‘He! may some one spear you! who told you that we are witches, my friend? You’ve just had a good meal over there so you come on a full stomach to pick a quarrel with me without cause. That’s a bad joke; you’re a nasty sly fellow. ’

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Sometimes a man will play a practical joke on his blood-brother, sending him on a fool's errand. I have a good example of this type of joke in one of my Azande texts:

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A. 'While you were coming here that elder brother of your father who lives over there has died of rupture, so they say.'

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B. 'Hm! I don't believe that, my friend, you have a poor sense of humour.'

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A. 'Very well, if you don't believe me, go and see for yourself.'

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B. 'All right, I'm just going.'

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He picks up his spear and he goes away and walks on till he reaches the homestead of his father's elder brother (where he sees a child) and says to him, 'Child, my blood-brother says that father's dead, is that true? The child replies, 'Who is spreading that lie if he spreads such baseless rumours perhaps he will peg out himself.'

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